

Africa



In Africa there is a greater variety of herbal traditions than on any other continent. During the colonial period, native herbal practices were largely suppressed, but today, in a marked turnaround, practitioners of conventional medicine often work closely with traditional healers.

The therapeutic use of medicinal plants in Africa dates back to the earliest times. Ancient Egyptian writings confirm that herbal medicines have been valued in North Africa for millennia. The Ebers papyrus (c. 1500 BCE), one of the oldest surviving medical texts, includes over 870 prescriptions and formulas, 700 medicinal herbs—including gentian (*Gentiana lutea*, p. 99), aloe (*Aloe vera*, p. 60), and opium poppy (*Papaver somniferum*, p. 244)—and covers conditions ranging from chest complaints to crocodile bite. The medicinal arts put forward in this and other Egyptian texts formed the intellectual foundation of classical medical practice in Greece, Rome, and the Arabic world.

Trade & the Arabian Influence

Herbal medicines have been traded between the Middle East, India, and northeastern Africa for at least 3,000 years. Herbs widely used in the Middle East, such as myrrh (*Commiphora molmol*, p. 85), originally came from Somalia and the Horn of Africa. From the 5th century CE to the 13th century, Arab physicians were at the forefront of medical advancement, and in the 8th century, the spread of Arabic culture across northern Africa had an influence on North African medicine that lasts to this day. In the mid-13th century, the botanist Ibn El Beitar published a *Materia Medica* that considerably increased the range of North African plant medicines in common use.

Ancient Beliefs & Indigenous Herbs

In the more remote areas of Africa, nomadic peoples, such as the Berber of Morocco and the Topnaar of Namibia, have herbal traditions that remain largely unaffected by changes in medicine in the world at large. For these peoples, healing is linked to a magical world in which spirits influence illness and death. In Berber culture, possession by a *djinn* (spirit) is a major cause of sickness, and herbs with “magical” properties are given to restore health. If the patient fails to recover, their condition is likely to be attributed to a curse or to the “evil eye.”

The Topnaar formerly depended completely on their environment for medicines, using the few medicinal plants that grow in such harsh and arid conditions. Although they are now heavily influenced by the Western way of life and have lost much of their plant lore, they continue to employ many indigenous plants medicinally. The stem of the seaweed *Ecklonia maxima*, for example, is roasted, mixed with petroleum jelly, and rubbed into wounds and burns, while *Hoodia currori*, a low-lying cactus, is stripped of its thorns and outer skin and eaten raw to treat coughs and colds.

Throughout Africa, thousands of different wild and locally grown medicinal plants are sold in the markets. Some are prescribed as medicines for home use. Others, such as kanna (*Membryanthemum* spp.) and iboga

Calumba (*Jateorhiza palmata*, p. 224) is a bitter herb that is used as a digestive remedy and as a means to improve the appetite.

Buchu (*Barosma betulina*, p. 71) has a diuretic and tonic effect within the urinary tract. It is infused in oil to make perfume.

Coffee (*Coffea arabica*, p. 192). According to legend, an Islamic mullah discovered the stimulating effect of coffee by observing the frisky behavior of goats who had grazed on the beans. Coffee is used medicinally to treat headaches.

Visnaga (*Ammi visnaga*, p. 62) is mentioned in an Egyptian medical text of c. 1500 BCE as an herb that relieves kidney stones. Visnaga seeds were used to clean the teeth.

Visnaga seeds

Visnaga leaves

Myrrh (*Commiphora molmol*, p. 85) exudes an astringent resin that is used to treat sore throats.

Devil's claw (*Harpagophytum procumbens*, p. 103) is anti-inflammatory, and is now widely used in the West.

Devil's claw rhizome

Devil's claw chopped rhizome